

Active Directory Home Lab

IT Helpdesk – Common Ticketing Scenarios

Platform: Oracle VirtualBox | OS: Windows Server 2022 + Windows 11

Overview

This section covers common day-to-day tasks that IT helpdesk and technical support staff handle in a real work environment. These are some of the most frequent tickets that come in, like password resets, account lockouts, account disabling, and account expiration. All scenarios are simulated using the Active Directory home lab environment.

Understanding such workflows is important not just for doing the job, but also for knowing the proper procedures and security practices that go along with each task.

Common Helpdesk Tickets

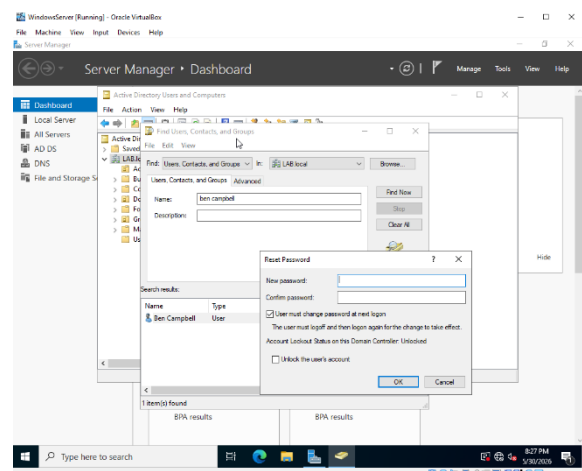
- **Password** – User forgot their password and cannot log in
- **Account Lockout** – User is locked out after too many failed login attempts
- **Account Disable/Enable** – Account needs to be disabled or re-enabled based on HR request
- **Account Expiration** – Account has reached its expiry date and needs to be reviewed

Ticket 1 – Password reset

One of the most common helpdesk tickets. A user calls in saying they forgot their password and cannot log into their computer.

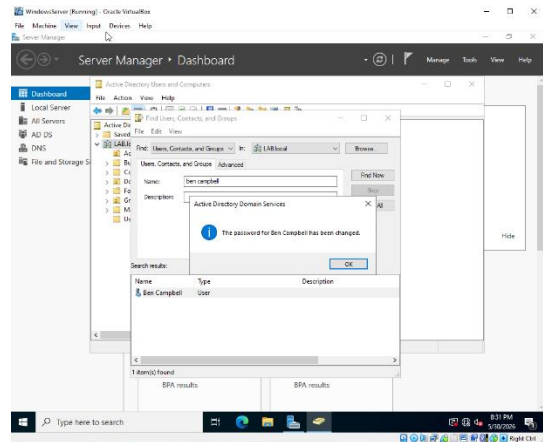
Steps

1. Ask the user for their **username**. Companies typically have thousands of accounts, so you need to locate the right one.
2. On the Windows server, open **Active Directory Users and Computers**.
3. To find the account quickly, click on **LAB.local** in the left panel, then go to



the top menu bar and click **Find objects in Active Directory Domain Services**. Search for the username or full name.

4. Once you locate the user, right-click on their account and select **Reset Password**.
5. Enter a temporary password and make sure **User must change password at next login** is checked. Click OK.
6. The password is now updated. Ask the user to log in with the temporary password – they will be prompted to set a new one of their own.
7. Once the user confirms they can log in successfully, **close the ticket**.



Note: Always check 'User must change password at next login'. Admins should never know a user's personal password – the temporary password is just to get them back in.

Best practice: After the reset, stay on the line with the user and confirm they can successfully log in before closing the ticket. This avoids a follow-up call.

Ticket 2 – Account Lockout

A user calls in saying they cannot log in and are getting an 'Account Locked Out' message. This happens when a user enters the wrong password too many times and the lockout policy kicks in.

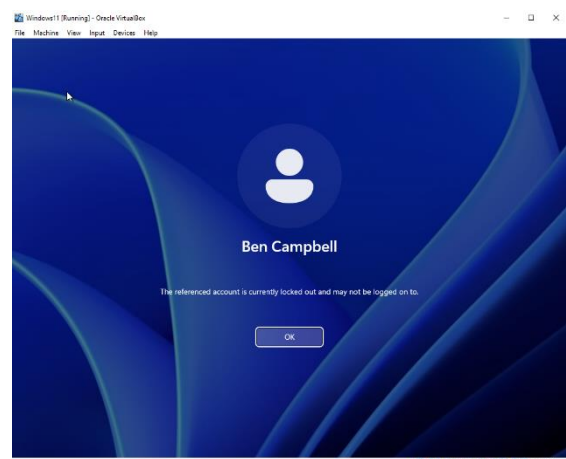
How the Lockout Policy Works

The account lockout behavior is controlled by a Group Policy Object (GPO) configured in the lab. The current settings are:

- **Lockout Threshold:** 3 invalid login attempts
- **Lockout Duration:** 0 – account stays locked until an admin manually unlocks it
- **Reset Counter:** 3 mins after the last failed attempt

How to unlock the Account

8. On the Windows Server, open **Active Directory Users and Computers**.
9. Locate the user's account – in this case, **Ben Campbell**.



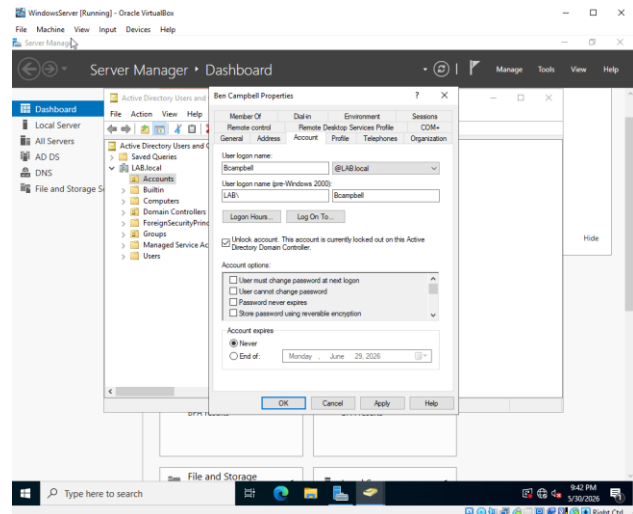
10. Double-click on the account and go to the **Account** tab.

11. There will be a checkbox that says **Unlock Account – This account is currently locked out on this Active Directory Domain Controller**. Check that box.

12. Click **Apply**, then **OK**. The account is now unlocked.

13. Ask the user if they remember their password. If not, proceed with a password reset before closing the ticket.

14. Confirm the user can log in successfully, then close the ticket.



Important: Do not unlock an account without verifying who is calling. Always confirm the user's identity before making any changes to their account.

Best Practice: After unlocking, always ask if they remember their password. It saves them from calling back 5 minutes later.

Ticket 3 – Account Disable/Enable

There are situations where an account needs to be disabled or re-enabled. HR, not the users themselves, almost always initiates this.

Common Reasons to Disable an Account.

- User has left the company
- User is on extended leave
- User is on medical leave or surgery
- HR wants to restrict access to the company network

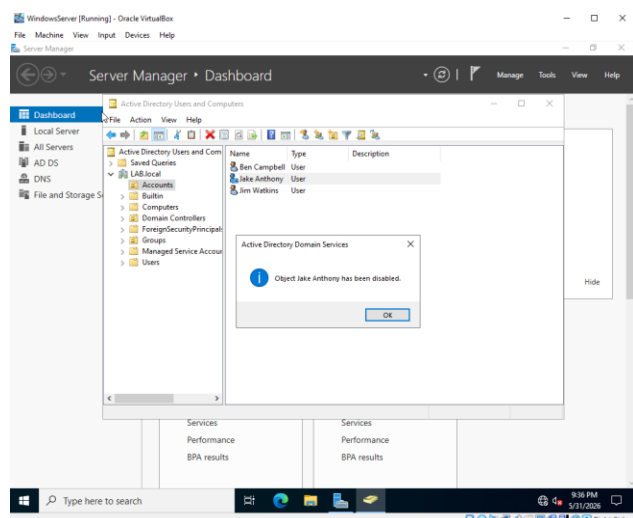
How to Disable an Account

15. Open **Active Directory Users and Computers**.

16. Locate the user account.

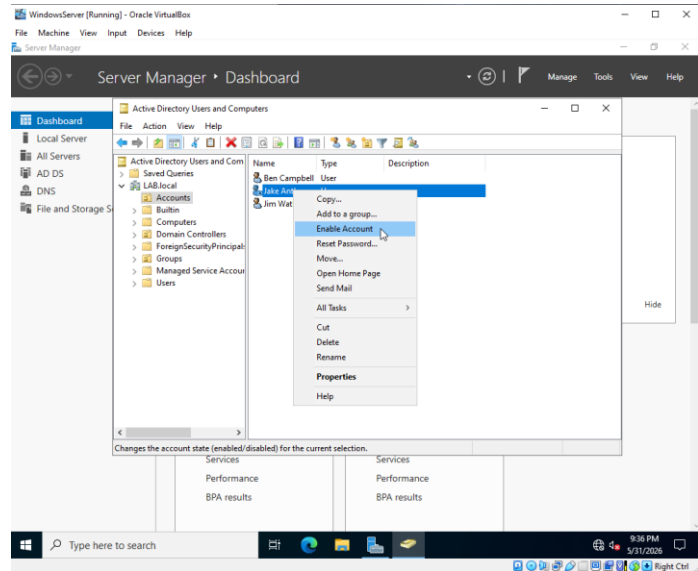
17. Right-click the account and select **Disable Account**.

18. The account icon will show a down arrow indicating it is disabled.



How to Re-enable an Account

19. If a user returns and asks you to re-enable their account, **do not do it right away**.
20. As a helpdesk or tech support, you must **confirm with HR first** before re-enabling any account.
21. Once HR confirms, right-click the account and select **Enable Account**.
22. Perform a password reset since the user likely forgot their old one.
23. Confirm with the user that they can log in, then close the ticket.



Important: Never re-enable a user account without HR confirmation, even if the user calls in directly requesting it. This is a security and compliance requirement.

Important: Never delete a user account even if the user has permanently left the company. Always disable it. Deleted accounts cannot be recovered and may break things like file ownership, email history, and audit trails.

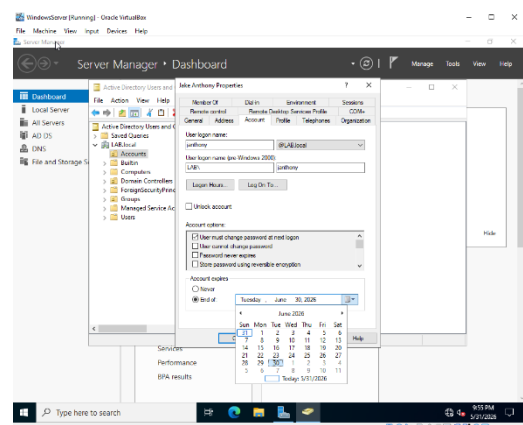
Ticket 4 – Account Expiration

Account expiration is a security feature that sets accounts to expire after a specified date or time period. This is common for contractors, temporary staff, or as a password aging policy.

Password Expiration

Most companies enforce a password change policy – typically every 60 days. This forces users to update their passwords regularly so the same credentials are never used for too long. When a password expires, the user will be prompted to change it at their next login.

Best Practice: This is handled automatically through Group Policy. No manual action is needed unless the user is having trouble changing their password.



Contractor Account Expiration

Contractor accounts typically have an end date set on their account. When that date is reached, the account automatically expires, and the contractor loses access.

Important: Never extend a contractor's account expiration date on your own as helpdesk or tech support. Always contact the manager or HR to get authorization first. Extending access without approval is a security policy violation.

Key Takeaways:

- **Always verify identity** – confirm who you are talking to before making any account changes
- **Never delete accounts** – disable them instead. Deleted accounts can cause serious issues down the line
- **Always check with HR** – for anything involving disabling, enabling, or extending accounts. HR confirmation is required.
- **Stay on the line** – always confirm the user can log in before closing any ticket.
- **Contractor accounts** – never extend expiration dates without manager or HR approval
- **Admins should never know user passwords** – always use temporary passwords with forced reset on next logon